

G-Talk The meeting on May 30 at the Paganini auditorium

Minors on the web Their protection is a priority

"We need to introduce digital education in schools for greater awareness"

Intervention by Agostino Ghiglia, member of the Authority for the protection of personal data

(by Anna Pinazzi, Gazzetta di Parma, May 9, 2024)

Social media and websites allow young people and children unlimited access to countless contents, some of which are not suitable for their age or, even worse, dangerous. It is possible to make the most of the resources of the internet, but it is also necessary to be aware of the risks. What, then, is the role of families, schools, and institutions in protecting minors online?

The first speakers of the free event organized by Gazzetta di Parma, "Rights on the web - Rights and protection of young people in the digital world," will focus on this concept, on May 30 at the Paganini auditorium (all information at [www.gtalk.it](http://www.gtalk.it)). The initiative will continue from 9:15 AM to the afternoon throughout the day, featuring a mix of prominent names and renowned experts who will engage in discussions. More than twenty authoritative voices from our time will take the stage at Paganini, including figures from the institutional, academic, entrepreneurial, sports, and communication worlds (among others, Ansa, Mediaset, Rai, Meta, Google).

#### Shared Responsibility

The first "round table" (there will be four in total) will delve into the role of "Institutions, law, and responsibility: actions for the protection of minors," opened by the intervention of the Minister of Education Giuseppe Valditara. A truly urgent topic, as highlighted by Ruben Razzante, professor of Information Law at the Catholic University of Milan and scientific director of GTalk: "The increasing use of social networks among young people is accompanied by significant risks for their mental health. Addiction to these platforms can trigger anxiety, depression, and, since young people are constantly exposed to comparisons with other users, also self-esteem issues - explains the expert. - Furthermore, the time spent online can erode interpersonal bonds, reducing face-to-face interactions and negatively affecting the quality of offline relationships: educating young people about the importance of responsible social media use is crucial to promote a balance in their emotional well-being and personal relationships."

#### Laws for Protection

In light of these dangers, monitoring young people and guiding them towards an appropriate and conscious use of digital tools is an essential task for parents and educators. But what is the state of the law? Are there adequate laws to truly protect minors in the online world? "The protection of young people on the internet requires compliance with existing regulations, which, moreover, need to be further strengthened to regulate specific situations such as sharenting - points out Ruben Razzante. - Laws that regulate privacy and the security of personal data are fundamental to protect minors from the collection and misuse of their information by third parties. Moreover, it is essential to apply legal provisions aimed at combating phenomena such as cyberbullying and the dissemination of pornographic material, imposing sanctions on offenders." Since minors are particularly vulnerable to online abuse, "it is crucial to adopt strict measures to ensure that their information is handled responsibly and securely," adds Razzante.

Thus, in the digital revolution we are experiencing, "the protection of minors, but more generally, of vulnerable individuals has become an absolute priority," declares Agostino Ghiglia, member of the Privacy Authority, who will also be present on May 30 at Paganini. New technologies inevitably mark a before and after: "Young generations spend and will spend a large part of their waking life on platforms, social media, and websites to study, play, and socialize - reflects Ghiglia. - If Boomers and Generation X transitioned from a 'materially lived life' to an 'online life,' Generation Z and Alpha will be increasingly connected, always on display, and much more exposed to the risks of the internet than their families can perceive."

#### How to Act

Something must change, even in education. According to Ghiglia, the civic education curriculum in

schools should be enhanced, transforming it into a "Digital Civic Education": "A mandatory subject from the first school cycle so that the so-called digital natives - explains the expert - not only know how to use the tools of their future but can do so in a conscious, aware, and educated manner."

Massimiliano Capitanio, journalist and Agcom commissioner, also emphasizes the importance of a new civic education: "When Aldo Moro first introduced civic education in Italy, he said the aim was to 'clean the future of our children.' Well, Agcom's work is in perfect continuity with that noble aspiration - he states. - Cleaning the future, and also the internet where, according to Save the Children data, 91.9% of 14-year-olds, 78.3% of 11-13-year-olds, and 44.6% of children aged 6 to 10 spend at least one hour a day online. Moreover, in the 11-19 age group, as much as 47% remain connected for over 5 hours a day across chats, video games, social media, and shopping."

The only way we have to protect minors online, on social media and beyond, is therefore to increase and enhance digital education. An objective that is evidently no longer postponable. "This is the age of responsibility: - concludes Capitanio - it is up to us to decide whether to be responsible citizens or passive consumers, and therefore potentially more vulnerable."